

NCAA Financial Analysis Report

Collegiate Athletics Financial Performance & Sustainability (FY20–2024)

Lamar University Athletics

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Financial Analysis Internship Project

Portfolio Disclaimer. This report is a portfolio-adapted version of a financial analysis project completed during an internship using NCAA Financial Reporting System (FRS) data. Certain financial figures have been converted to indexed or percentage-based representations to preserve analytical insight while respecting institutional confidentiality. This document is intended to demonstrate data analytics, financial trend evaluation, and data visualization capabilities.

Abstract

This report presents a five-year financial analysis of an NCAA Division I athletics program using Financial Reporting System (FRS) data from fiscal years 2020 through 2024. The analysis evaluates revenue and expenditure trends, institutional dependency ratios, expense composition, and sport-level financial performance. Findings indicate a near break-even operational model with increasing structural reliance on institutional allocations. Revenue generation remains concentrated in a small number of sports, while the majority of programs operate as subsidized entities. The department exhibits a stable but institutionally constrained financial architecture.

Keywords: NCAA athletics finance, institutional dependency, revenue composition, sport-level analysis, allocated revenue, generated revenue, FRS data

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1. Introduction

This report presents a comprehensive financial analysis of Lamar University Athletics using five years of NCAA Financial Reporting System (FRS) data spanning fiscal years 2020 through 2024. The study evaluates revenue and expenditure trends, institutional dependency ratios, financial structure, and overall financial sustainability at both the department and sport levels.

The findings indicate that the athletics program operates as a highly subsidized model in which financial sustainability depends heavily on institutional support, while meaningful revenue generation is concentrated in football and a small number of additional programs.

2. Data and Methodology

The analysis draws upon NCAA FRS reports for FY20–FY24. Data from each annual report were extracted and organized into structured analytical models to ensure consistency across fiscal years. The dataset was standardized across several components: overall financial totals, revenue composition, expense breakdowns, sport-level analysis, and department-level structure.

The analytical approach involved calculating composition percentages, evaluating year-over-year growth rates, separating generated and allocated revenue streams, and organizing expense categories into broader functional groupings. For this portfolio version, all absolute dollar values have been converted to indexed representations (FY20 = 100) or percentage-based metrics to preserve analytical insight while respecting institutional confidentiality.

3. Overall Financial Trends (FY20–FY24)

Over the five-year period, total revenue and total expenses moved in close parallel, indicating consistently near break-even operations. Fiscal year 2021 reflects a notable contraction associated with COVID-19 disruptions, with both revenue and expenses declining approximately 12–13% from FY20 levels. A steady recovery followed beginning in FY22.

From FY22 through FY24, both revenue and expenses increased meaningfully, reaching levels approximately 26–27% above FY20 by the end of the period. However, operating margins remained minimal throughout, as expenses continued to track revenue closely. This sustained pattern suggests that the athletics program operates within a balanced, budget-driven system rather than a surplus-generating model.

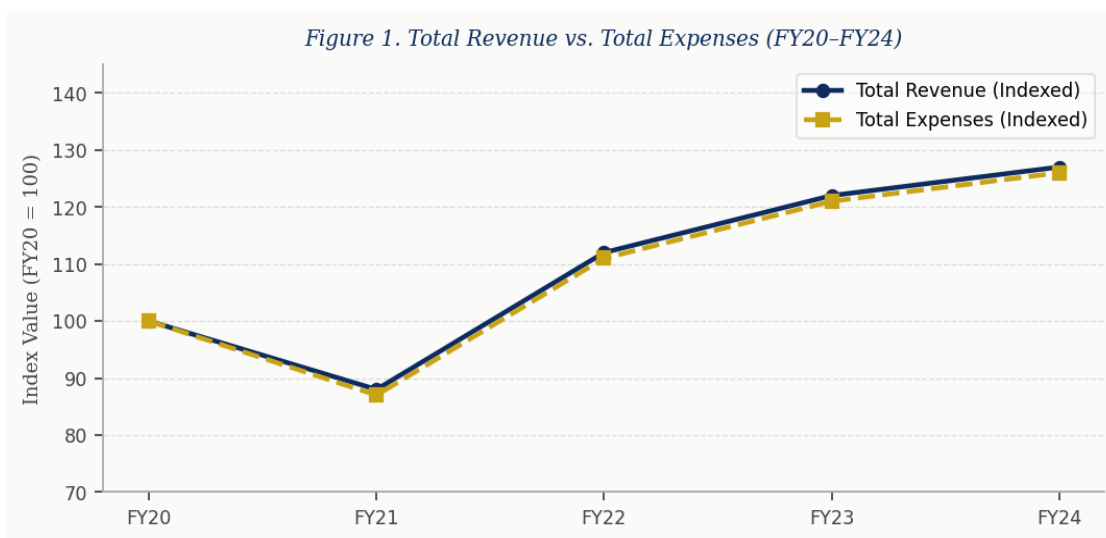


Figure 1. Total Revenue vs. Total Expenses — Indexed Scale (FY20 = 100)

4. Revenue Composition Analysis

Revenue was categorized into two primary streams: allocated revenue and generated revenue. Allocated revenue encompasses institutional support, student fees, and indirect support, while generated revenue includes ticket sales, donor contributions, media guarantees, sponsorships, and similar externally sourced income.

The analysis demonstrates that allocated revenue consistently represented the majority of total revenue and increased over time in both absolute and proportional terms. Generated revenue, by contrast, remained volatile and did not demonstrate sustained long-term growth. The share of generated revenue declined from approximately 23% in FY20 to 18% in FY24, with a notable dip to 17% in FY23. Recent expansion in total revenue — particularly in FY23 and FY24 — was driven primarily by institutional allocations rather than internal revenue generation, indicating deepening structural dependency over the five-year period.

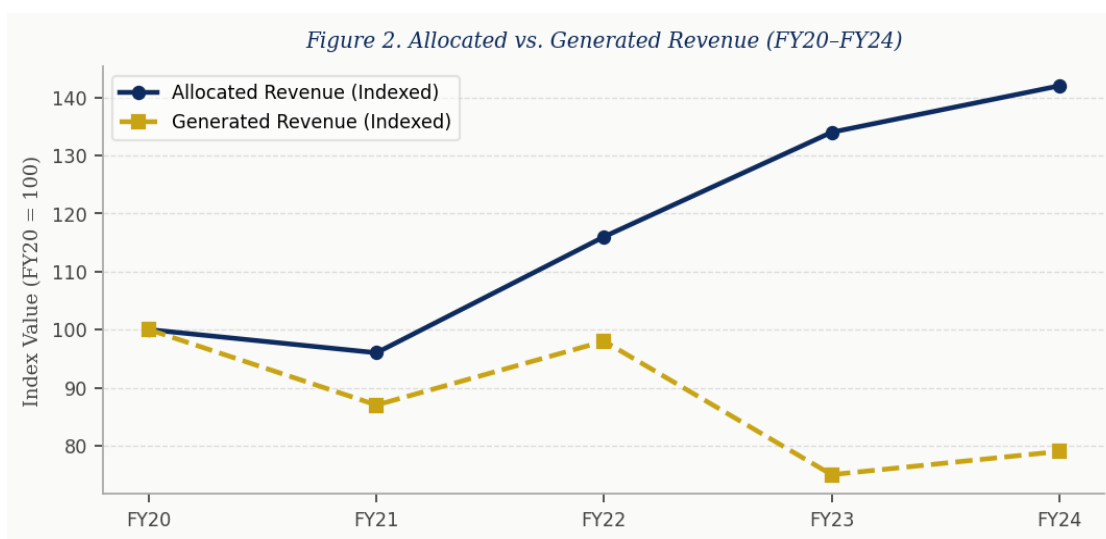


Figure 2. Allocated vs. Generated Revenue — Indexed Scale (FY20 = 100)

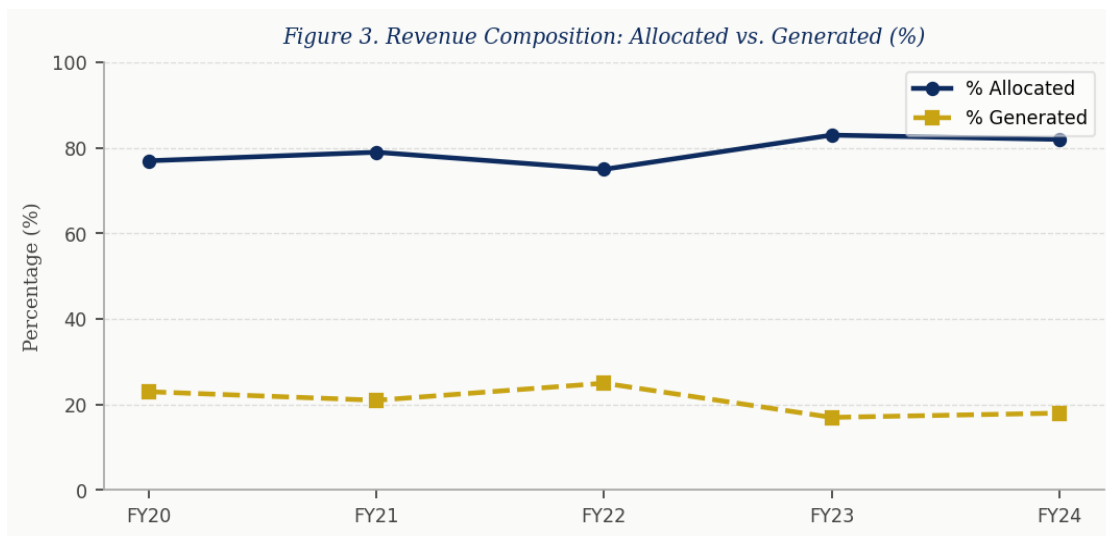


Figure 3. Revenue Composition (%): Allocated vs. Generated (FY20–FY24)

5. Expense Structure Analysis

Expenses were organized into six major functional categories: student aid, personnel costs, team travel, equipment and uniforms, facilities and overhead, and a residual other category. Personnel costs and student aid together consistently accounted for approximately 60–67% of total expenses across the five-year period, establishing them as the dominant cost drivers.

The expense structure remained notably stable throughout the period, with only modest variation in specific categories. Team travel expenditures declined temporarily during FY21 due to pandemic-related restrictions before returning to baseline levels. The dominance of fixed and semi-fixed cost categories — particularly personnel and facilities obligations — substantially limits the department's short-term financial flexibility in response to revenue fluctuations.

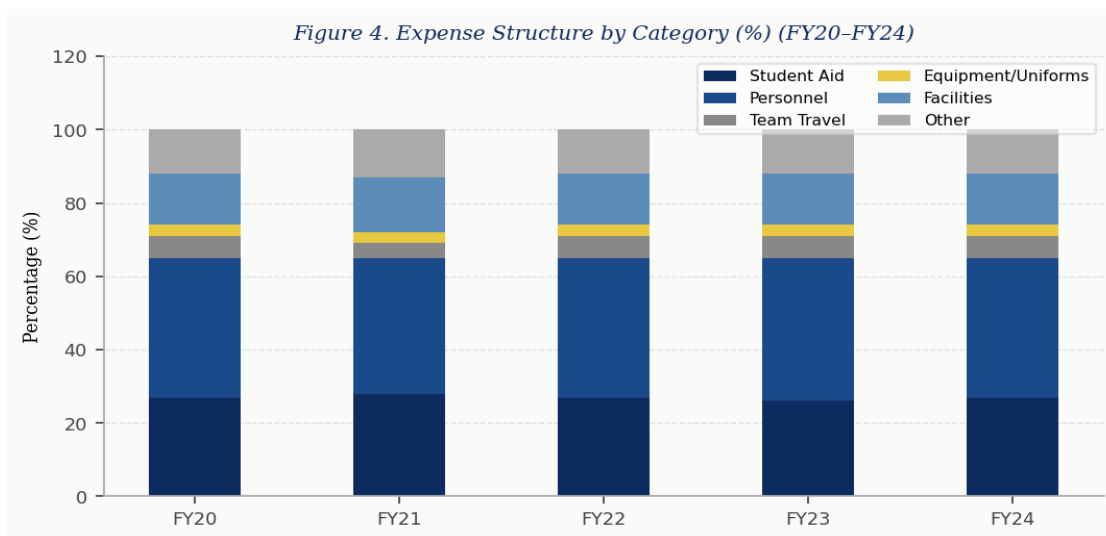


Figure 4. Expense Structure by Functional Category (%) (FY20–FY24)

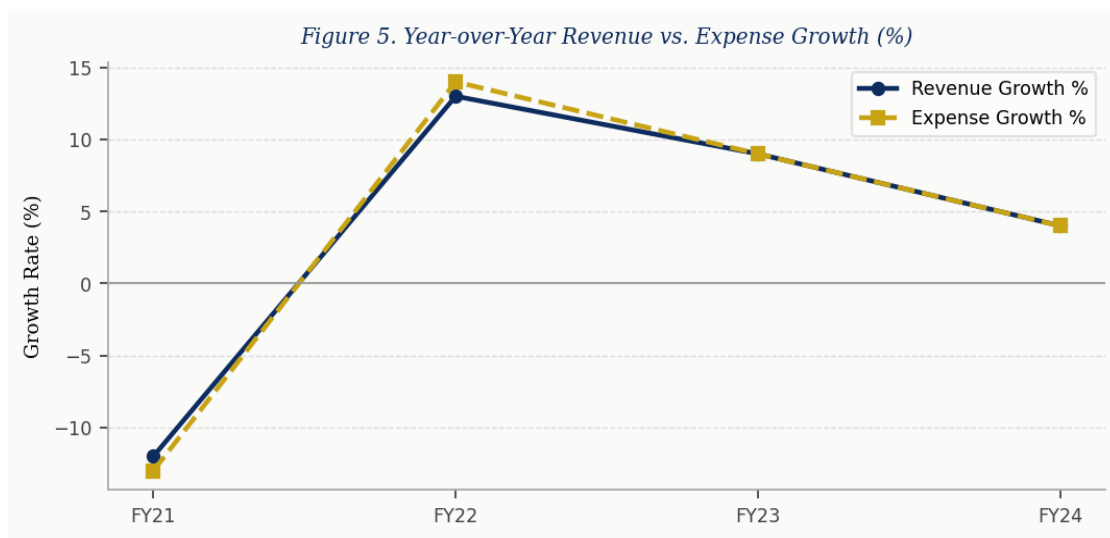


Figure 5. Year-over-Year Revenue vs. Expense Growth Rate (%)

6. Sport-by-Sport Financial Analysis

A detailed sport-level analysis was conducted using FY24 data as the primary reference year. The results reveal substantial variation in self-generated revenue capacity across programs, with revenue generation concentrated in a small number of sports.

Football generates the highest proportion of its own revenue at approximately 31%, significantly outperforming all other sports on this measure. Men's basketball and baseball each demonstrate moderate self-generated revenue, at roughly 20% and 19% respectively, but both remain heavily dependent on institutional allocations for the majority of their funding. Men's golf represents a notable outlier among non-revenue sports, generating approximately 15% of its revenue independently.

Most remaining sports generate less than 10% of their revenue from external sources. Several programs — including women's tennis, men's tennis, and track and field/cross country — generate negligible revenue independently. In aggregate, the majority of sports rely on institutional allocations for more than 90% of total revenue, confirming that most athletic programs operate as subsidized entities rather than self-sustaining financial units.

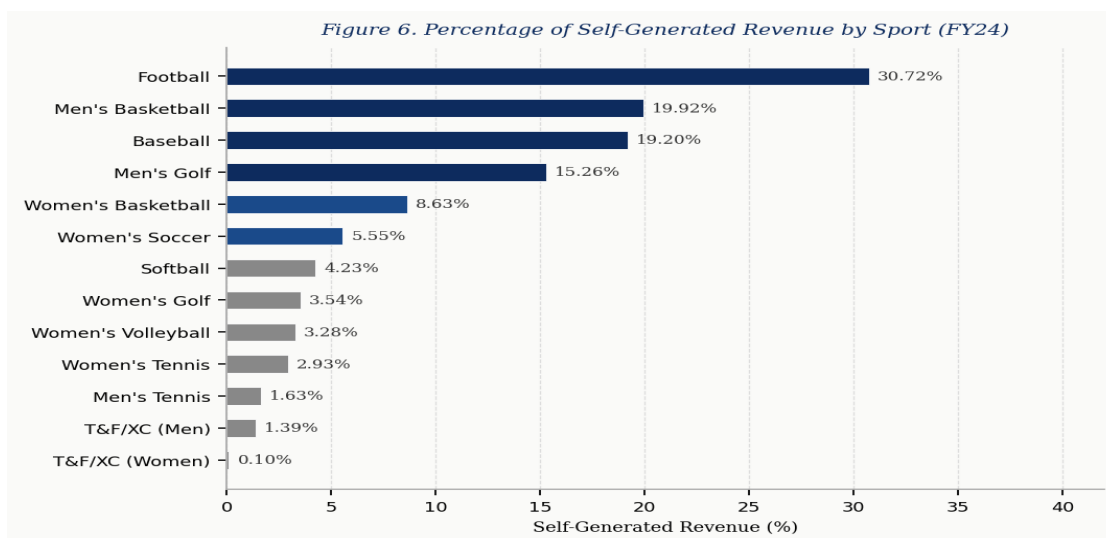


Figure 6. Percentage of Self-Generated Revenue by Sport (FY24)

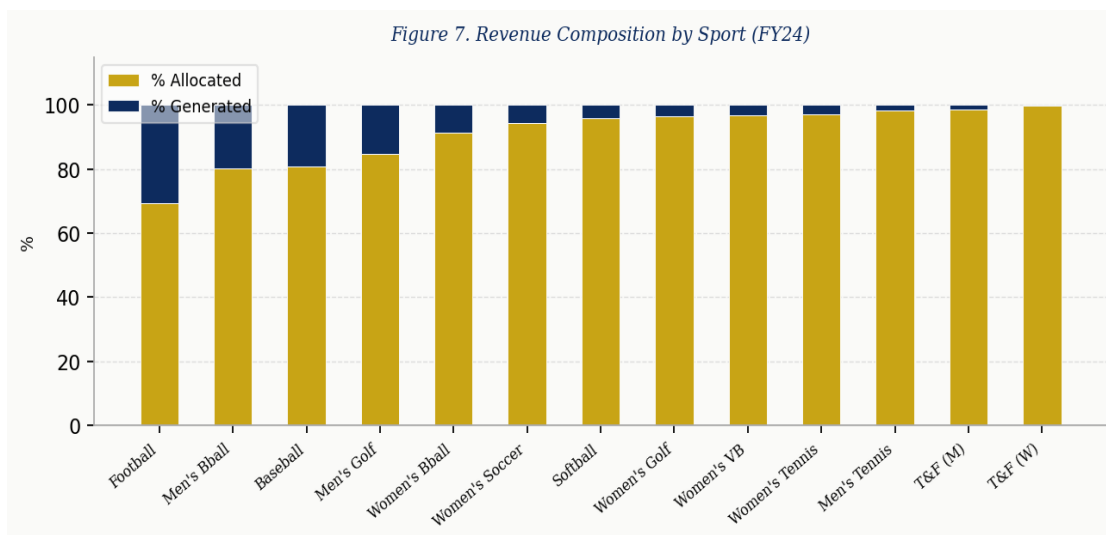


Figure 7. Revenue Composition by Sport — Allocated vs. Generated (FY24)

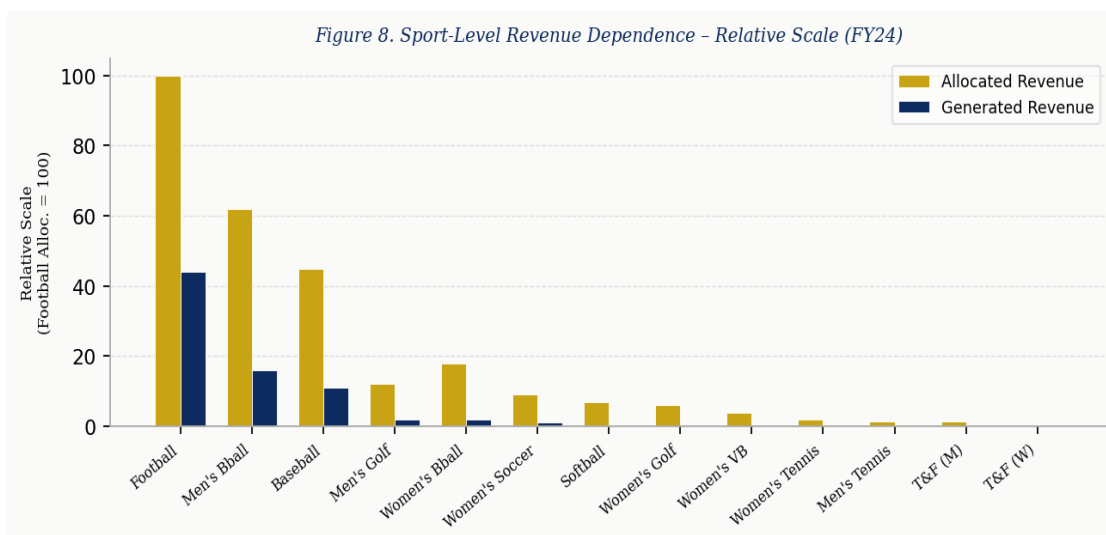


Figure 8. Sport-Level Revenue Dependence — Relative Scale (FY24)

7. Sport-Level Trends (FY23 vs. FY24)

A year-over-year comparison between FY23 and FY24 reveals notable movement across several key programs, though no fundamental structural shift in the overall financial model occurred. Football demonstrated the strongest improvement, with self-generated revenue increasing from approximately 24.5% in FY23 to 30.7% in FY24 — a meaningful gain of approximately 6 percentage points.

Men's basketball moved in the opposite direction, becoming more reliant on institutional support as its generated revenue share declined modestly. Baseball remained comparatively stable, while women's soccer showed notable improvement, increasing its generated share from approximately 1.5% to 5.6% over the same period. Despite these individual movements, the broader structural pattern remained unchanged: revenue generation continues to be concentrated in a small number of programs, with most continuing to operate under a heavily subsidized model.

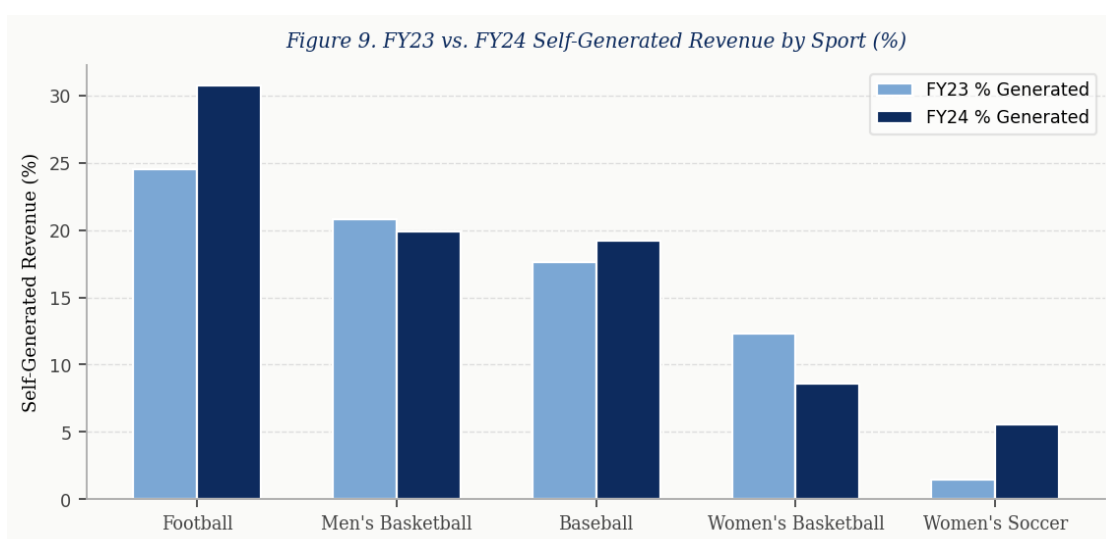


Figure 9. FY23 vs. FY24 Self-Generated Revenue Comparison by Sport (%)

8. Department-Level Financial Structure (FY24)

At the department level, the revenue structure is predominantly driven by institutional sources. Approximately 75–76% of department-level revenue derives from direct institutional support, student fees, and facility-related allocations. Direct institutional support alone represents approximately 33% of total department revenue, while student fees account for an additional 23%. Indirect institutional support contributes a further 12%, bringing total institutionally sourced revenue to approximately 68% before facility-related allocations are included.

External revenue streams — including donor contributions, corporate sponsorships, and ticket sales — remain comparatively limited in scope. Ticket sales in particular represent only a negligible fraction of total department revenue, reflecting the challenges typical of mid-major collegiate athletics programs in generating gate revenue.

On the expenditure side, department costs are concentrated in fixed categories. Administrative and support staff salaries represent the single largest expense item at approximately 30% of department-level expenditures. Facilities debt and lease obligations account for approximately 20%, while direct overhead contributes an additional 14%. Together, these three categories account for nearly two-thirds of total department expenses, underscoring the structural rigidity of the cost base.

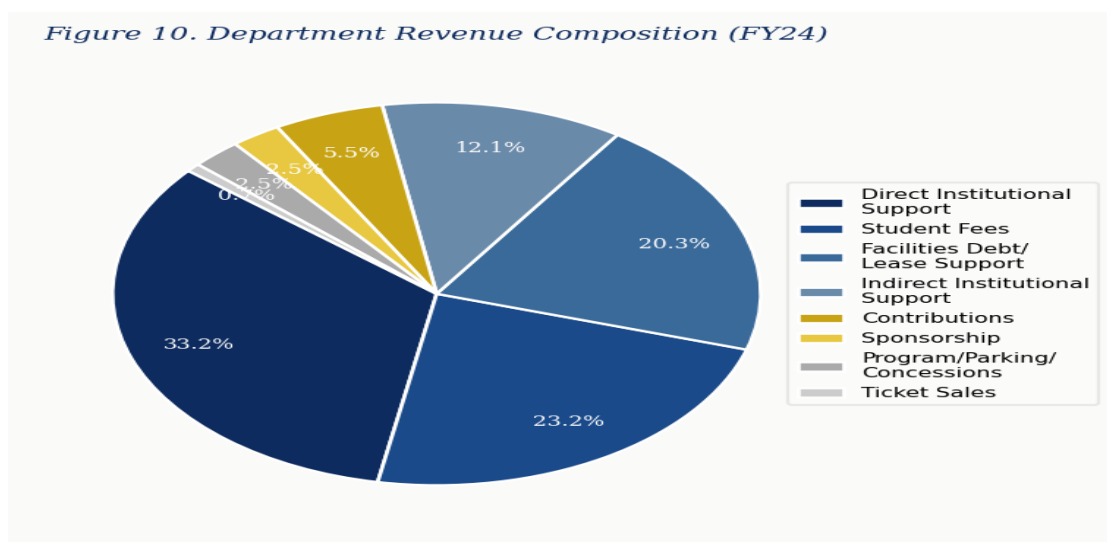


Figure 10. Department Revenue Composition by Source (FY24)

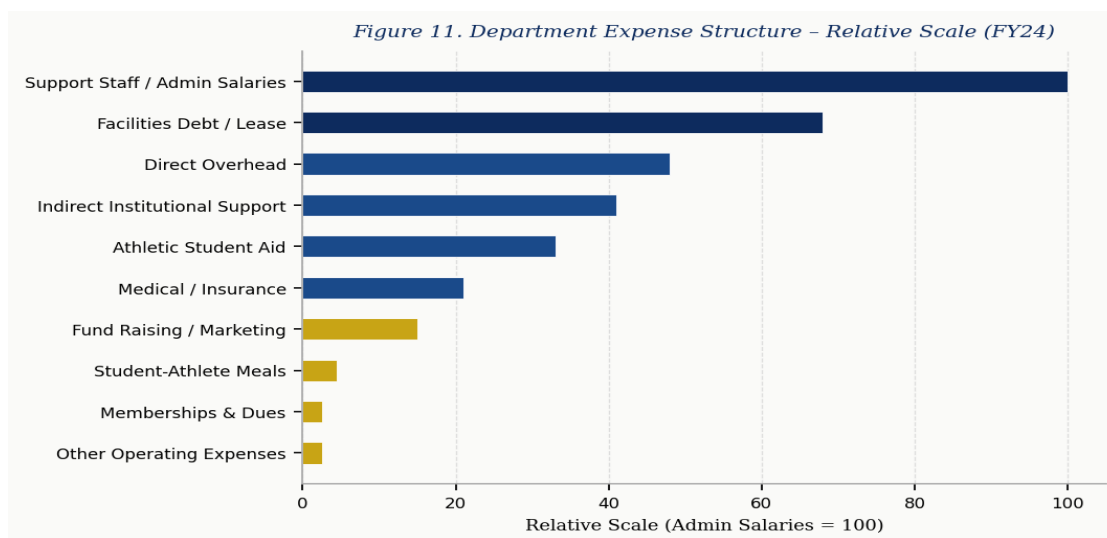


Figure 11. Department Expense Structure — Relative Scale (FY24)

9. Key Insights and Implications

- **Near Break-Even Operations.** Revenue and expenses tracked closely across all five fiscal years, consistent with a budget-driven management model with minimal surplus generation.
 - **Deepening Institutional Dependency.** The share of allocated revenue grew from approximately 77% in FY20 to 82% in FY24, as growth in institutional allocations outpaced any recovery in generated revenue.
 - **Fixed-Cost Structure Limits Flexibility.** Personnel costs and student aid together represent 60–67% of total expenses, substantially constraining the department's ability to adjust costs in response to revenue shocks.
 - **Football as the Primary Revenue Generator.** At approximately 31% self-generated, football operates as the single most financially self-sufficient sport and represents the clearest avenue for expanding independent revenue.
 - **Structural Subsidy Across Most Programs.** The majority of sports rely on institutional allocations for over 90% of total revenue, functioning as service programs rather than revenue-generating units.
 - **Financial Stability with Structural Constraints.** While the department is operationally stable under its current model, long-term financial independence is constrained by its reliance on institutional and student-fee funding streams.
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10. Conclusion

In conclusion, Lamar University Athletics operates under an institutionally supported financial model designed to sustain a broad portfolio of athletic programs rather than to generate financial surplus. The reliance on institutional funding — compounded by a structurally rigid cost base and limited external revenue generation — indicates that long-term sustainability will depend either on the continuation of robust institutional support or on deliberate strategic investment in revenue-generating capacity.

Football represents the most viable near-term pathway for expanding self-generated revenue, given its comparatively higher level of external revenue activity. Most non-revenue sports will continue to require institutional subsidy as a structural feature of the department's financial architecture. While the department appears financially stable within its current operational model, policymakers should consider the long-term implications of increasing institutional dependency and evaluate opportunities to diversify revenue streams across the athletics portfolio.